

In an era when the youth culture was openly challenging authority in America on many fronts, strong leadership of young men in combat also became a special challenge. The expansion of the Army had left a deficit in experienced small unit leadership—junior officers and sergeants. While most men placed in these roles performed well, there were some who exposed units to ambushes, firefights, or petty harassment. Six-month rotations of officers and one-year tours of duty in-country also made unit cohesion difficult and threatened the ability of leaders to command the respect of their men. Particularly disturbing was the increasing incidence of fragging: the intentional use of a fragmentation grenade against unit leaders. Fragging was both murder and an attack on authority. Drugs and alcohol played a part in most of these disputes, threatening to undermine discipline. Marijuana and amphetamines, commonly used by young Americans in the late 1960s, were cheap and easy to obtain throughout Vietnam.

■ **60** PERCENT of GIs used drugs to escape anxiety or boredom, according to a 1970 report by the Pentagon.



Counting the days

A tank crew member nicknamed Big Buddha stares morosely at his combat base in 1971. A hand-painted sign on the tank's protective shield expressed his desire to leave Vietnam, as ever more US units left the country.